

# Parth Chawla

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## RESEARCH AREAS

Development Economics, Labor Economics, Human Capital, Firm Productivity, Migration

## ACADEMIC EXPERIENCE

2021 – 2026     Ph.D. in Agricultural and Resource Economics, University of California, Davis  
2018 – 2019     M.Sc. in Economics, Trinity College Dublin  
2014 – 2017     B.Sc. in Physics, Royal Holloway, University of London

## DISSERTATION COMMITTEE

|                                                      |                                 |                                                      |
|------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Prof. Travis Lybbert (Chair)                         | Prof. Arman Rezaee              | Prof. J. Edward Taylor                               |
| Department of Agricultural and<br>Resource Economics | Department of Economics         | Department of Agricultural and<br>Resource Economics |
| University of California, Davis                      | University of California, Davis | University of California, Davis                      |
| tlybbert@ucdavis.edu                                 | abrezaee@ucdavis.edu            | jetaylor@ucdavis.edu                                 |

## WORKING PAPERS

**Chawla, P.** 2026. “Local Human Capital Development and Firm Resilience: Evidence from the 1997 Indonesian Crisis.” Working paper. Available at SSRN. (Job Market Paper)

Summary: Do returns to human capital rise during crises? This paper examines whether human capital accumulation created by Indonesia’s INPRES school construction program in the 1970s improved firm resilience in the 1997 Asian Financial Crisis. I find that each additional school per 1,000 children increased real labor productivity and output during the crisis period by 2.7 and 3.3 percent, respectively. INPRES induced changes in the local pre-crisis workforce composition that shifted workers toward more skill-intensive production work. I argue that these skills became particularly valuable during the crisis, when firms faced disruptions. Consistent with this mechanism, INPRES had larger effects in sectors with higher import intensity, where adjustment demands were greater. I show that the local abundance of skilled workers in high-INPRES districts kept wages relatively lower, enabling plants to retain more of them when they were most valuable.

## PUBLICATIONS

Barriga-Cabanillas, O., **Chawla, P.**, Redaelli, S. and Yoshida, N. 2025. “Estimating Poverty in Afghanistan Without Consumption Data: An Imputation-Based Approach.” *The Journal of Development Studies*, 1–22.

Summary: This paper uses a machine learning-based survey-to-survey imputation method to estimate poverty in Afghanistan following the Taliban’s return to power in August 2021. A model trained on the 2019/20 Expenditure and Labor Force Survey is used to predict household consumption in the 2023 Afghanistan Welfare Monitoring Survey, a phone survey drawn from the same sampling frame. The results show that 48.3 percent of the population was poor as of April-June 2023, a 4 percentage point decline since the same months in 2020. This decline was driven by falling rural poverty, while urban poverty remained unchanged.

## RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

“Predicting Mexico-to-US Migration with Machine Learning for Counterfactual Analysis,” with J. Edward Taylor

Summary: Reliable tools to predict migration are increasingly important amid rising climate and economic risks, and demographic shifts. Tree-based machine learning models can uncover complex, nonlinear relationships that conventional models often miss and can be used to simulate responses to shocks. Migration data are costly to collect, so models must perform well with readily available data. We first train a LightGBM model on an ideal dataset, a panel tracking the employment locations of 10,739 individuals from 1980 to 2007, and achieve high predictive accuracy. Using this as a benchmark, we then train a model on just four years of data without migration histories. By adding public weather data, this restricted model approaches benchmark performance (within 0.1 F1 score). Counterfactual shocks show that a 10% rise in temperature reduces migration by 13% the following year, a 10% increase in age lowers it by 17%, and a 10% drop in income by 18%.

“Are Technologies Appropriate for Developing Country Skills? Evidence from Vietnamese Manufacturing,” with Francesca de Nicola and Jonathan Timmis (World Bank East Asia Pacific)

Summary: We test the “inappropriate technology” hypothesis in Vietnam by examining whether productivity gains from imported technologies adopted by manufacturing firms are lower when those technologies are less suited to local factor endowments. We use a novel firm-level panel from 2009 to 2017 that identifies the country of origin of each firm’s primary manufacturing technology and define “inappropriateness” as the difference between a firm’s skill intensity and the skill abundance of the country from which it sources technology. Exploiting large-scale tariff liberalization during this period, and linking technology product descriptions to tariff schedules using an LLM-based approach, we show a strong and statistically significant relationship between tariff reductions and greater skill mismatch. This effect is driven by firms shifting toward sourcing technologies from more skill-abundant countries than their own workforce: a 10 percentage-point decline in tariff exposure increases positive mismatch by about 0.03 standard deviations. We then instrument mismatch to estimate how productivity gains vary with technology appropriateness.

“Firm Networks, Risk Sharing and Resilience to Shocks Among Small Firms in Tanzania,” with Daniel Putman and Jess Rudder

Summary: We examine the role of formal and informal networks among small firms in helping them cope with shocks. Using novel survey data that we collected in rural Tanzania, we estimate complete firm networks and analyze how network characteristics, such as centrality and clustering, shape firms’ exposure to shocks and their responses, including access to credit, performance, productivity, and entry and exit.

“Financial Literacy and Small Firm Performance in Uganda,” with Ester Agasha, Andrew Hobbs, Travis Lybbert, Nathalie Nyanga, and Bruce Wydick

“Local Economic Impacts of Cash Transfers to Refugees and Asylum Seekers in Mexico, Mauritania, and Moldova,” with Justin Kagin and J. Edward Taylor

## PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

2023 – Present    Consultant, The World Bank, Washington, D.C.

2023 – 2024      Graduate Student Researcher, UC Davis (Prof. J. Edward Taylor)

2022              Research Intern, United Nations Development Programme, New York, NY

2022              Research Assistant, University of Michigan (Prof. Yusuf Neggers)

2019 – 2021      Research Associate, Evidence for Policy Design (Harvard Kennedy School)  
(based in Delhi, India)

## GRANTS, FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

2024 – 2026      Internal Grants (3 awards, \$6,000), UC Davis

|             |                                                                           |
|-------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2024        | Giannini Dissertation Fellowship (\$21,500 stipend)                       |
| 2024        | Giannini Foundation Mini-Grant (\$20,000), with J. Edward Taylor          |
| 2024        | Henry A. Jastro Graduate Research Award (\$3,000)                         |
| 2021 – 2022 | Provost’s Fellowship (\$25,000 stipend), UC Davis                         |
| 2014        | International Excellence Scholarship (50% tuition waiver), Royal Holloway |

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Main Instructor: Economic Development (UC Davis, 2024)

Teaching Assistant: Operations Research & Management Science, Economic Development, Econometric Methods, Agricultural Labor, Intermediate Microeconomics, Math & Statistics for Economics (Average evaluation score of 4/5 from 139 responses)

Teaching Fellow: Math Foundations Course (Ashoka University, 2018)

## PRESENTATIONS

2026 9th Linked Employer-Employee Data Workshop (scheduled), AAEA Annual Meeting (scheduled)

2025 AAEA & WAEA Joint Annual Meeting (Best Poster Award Recipient), Japan Economic Policy Association, World Bank-LSMS Conference “Better Data for Better Jobs and Lives”, UC Davis Development Workshop, Giannini Student Research Conference

## TECHNICAL SKILLS

**Programming:** Python (pandas, NumPy, scikit-learn), R, SQL/MySQL, Stata

**Machine Learning and Causal Inference:** Linear/Logistic Regression, Random Forests, Gradient Boosting, LightGBM, DiD, RDD, IV, PSM, Synthetic Controls, Panel Data Econometrics

**Tools and Platforms:** LLM APIs, agentic workflows, REST APIs, Git, Unix, Markdown, AWS (EC2, RDS), R Shiny, SurveyCTO

## BLOG ARTICLES

“Government Intervention in India and Taiwan Affects Global Rice Markets” (with Tzu-Hui Chen), Ag Data News (2022)

## SERVICE

Referee: Journal of Agriculture and Food Research

Other: Grad School Application Mentor

## LANGUAGES

English (Native/Bilingual), Hindi (Native/Bilingual), Korean (Beginner)